Pitfalls to avoid in interview questions

Overview

When creating an interview script, your goal is to solicit rich data about the participant's life, experiences, and values. You should refer to the environment in which the interview takes place, formulate the questions in a simple and understandable way, and make the participant feel comfortable responding to them.

The following are ways in which interview questions can be confusing or ineffective. Use this guide to learn how to avoid these pitfalls and create a more in-depth interview protocol.

1. Short-answer questions

- Short-answer questions are questions that can be answered with 1-2 words. These include, for example, yes/no questions or scale question ("On a scale of 1-10").
- Avoid short-answer questions, because they don't allow you to take advantage of the interpersonal connection with the participant and dig for stories that will provide insight about the participant. Such questions are useful in surveys, but not in interviews.
- Instead, use open-ended phrases such as "Tell me about" or "Describe a time when you…".
- If you must ask short-answer questions, always follow up with requests for more in-depth explanations such as "why", "how", or "can you tell me more about this".

2. Leading questions

- Leading questions guide and bias participant's toward a particular answer. They include assumptions about the participant that might not necessarily be true. The following questions are examples of leading questions:
    - "When you struggle with [X], what do you do?" This question leads the participant to only think about challenges, not about successes. It assumes that the participant struggles with X.
    - "Would you like an app that would help you do [X]?" This question assumes that the participant needs help with X, and that an app is the only possible solution.
- Avoid leading questions, because they don't provide you with the true opinions or thoughts of the participant about a topic.
- Instead, consider what assumptions you included in formulating the question, and remove these assumptions to ask the questions in a non-biased way. For example, you can ask two questions, one about successes and one about struggles or failures. You can ask about the degree to which they need help with X and what they think could help them do it better.

3. General questions

- General questions ask the participant about typical activities, behaviors, or interactions they have in their life. Questions that are formulated in the present tense or that adding to them the phrases "on average", "in general" or "typically" doesn't change their meaning, are often general questions. An example for a general question is "What do you use your credit card

for?" This question is in present tense, and adding to it "typically" doesn't change the meaning of it. It is therefore a general question.

- Avoid general questions because they lead to general answers, which don't give you the true picture of the participant's life, behaviors, and beliefs.
- Instead, ask about specific recent events. For example, you can ask "In the last time you used your credit card, what was it for? Tell me about that time." Then, follow up with additional questions that will let you dig for details about that specific event: where, when, with whom, what happened, what went right, what went wrong, how did you feel, what happened after that, etc.

4. Double-barreled questions

- Double-barreled questions are questions in which multiple questions are lumped together in one. Examples include:
    - How many and what kind of objects to you carry in your wallet?
    - What do you find good and bad about your wallet?
    - What would you add, change, or remove?
- Avoid double-barreled questions because they are confusing to the participant, and you are likely to get an answer to only one of the questions hidden in them.
- Instead, break up the question to multiple questions, and ask them one-by-one, giving the participant the opportunity to answer them one at a time.